Art and Reconstruction in *The Island* through *Antigone*

In response to Question 2

A play within a play is often employed to create analogies between the larger work and the smaller play within it. However, Fugard's use of *Antigone* in *The Island* goes beyond drawing a parallel between the two plays—here, he propagates the reconstructive power of art.

The word 'reconstruction' itself has a two-fold implication: the need for reconstruction necessarily entails a prior destruction, while the act of reconstruction suggests a creation or transformation from the original. In the context of *The Island*, this reconstruction is a constant process—the breaking and rebuilding of a man's constitution. As defined by the opening stage directions, the men are subject to a painful, systematic dismantling by Hodoshe, which becomes the undertone of the rest of the narrative. The question that arises, therefore, is how art, through *Antigone*, reconstructs the prisoners in *The Island*.

Secluded on the island, art becomes an anchor that gives meaning to them outside of their abuse. Hodoshe nearly succeeds in his attempts to turn the men against each other, but art and its pursuit unites them. They feel responsible in performing for each other, as evidenced by John attempting to guilt Winston into doing *Antigone* by telling him "we promised the chaps we'd do something." (p. 199). Art drives a sense of solidarity in the way all the inmates come together to put on a show, even smuggling rope for John to use as a prop (p. 203).

The act of John making props using nails, cans and rope is also a form of art: handcrafting. The conversion of minimal materials found in prison to works of art is a literal reconstruction—but a metaphorical reconstruction, through memory, is framed when John punctuates the completion of Creon's medallion by recalling the production of *Antigone* in St. Stephen's Hall. Here, Fugard foreshadows Winston's transformation through theatre in *The*

Island, by using the figure of Georgie, who was "short . . . but by the time the play was finished, he was as tall as the roof." (p. 202).

This scene compounds an understanding of the role of art in memory: it allows the prisoners to remember the reality of the outside world, and subsequently, grounds them to their identity and principles. This reconstruction of ideals is the crux of the play—Winston's gradual loss of conviction in the anti-apartheid ideals is reflected in his dismissive attitude to *Antigone*. Fugard, through John, emphasizes that brushing off the importance of the play is to be indoctrinated into "Hodoshe's talk" (p. 210). When Winston ends both plays by "tearing off his wig and confronting the audience" as himself, he also recalls and reconstructs his choice to protest "because [he] honoured those things to which honour belongs." (p. 227).

In this way, Fugard imbibes art in *The Island* as a reconstructive force. Though Hodoshe constantly breaks the spirit of the prisoners, they rely on art to remain connected to both each other and their principles—and in the process, they make and remake themselves.